having previously discussed the idea with Burmese leader Aung San. India made considerable efforts to secure participation from Southeast Asia. ‘Asia is again finding itself,’ Nehru declared while greeting the 300-plus delegates present from China, Korea, Turkey, Egypt, Iran, Afghanistan, Mongolia, Tibet and across Southeast Asia, among other places. [63] ‘If the Indians played a leading role in the Asian Conference, it was partly because theirs was the host country, and partly because they believe they have a big destiny in Asia,’ an American journalist reported from the venue. [64]

In the 1950s, India was actively involved in diplomacy to settle disputes and facilitate resolutions related to China, Korea, Japan, and Indochina. After the Korean War broke out, India facilitated communications between the United States and Communist China, in their absence of diplomatic relations. Famously, India’s Ambassador to Beijing K.M. Panikkar warned Western diplomats that China intended to enter the Korean War if American forces crossed the thirty-eighth parallel on the Korean peninsula. His warning went unheeded, and China entered the war on North Korea’s side. [65] As the war progressed, and India provided a medical mission to UN forces, it was also involved in the Neutral Nations Repatriation Commission (NNRC) that exchanged prisoners of war between the North and South.

India was also diplomatically engaged in Indochina as the region decolonized from France. India’s role included negotiations to ensure Laotian neutrality and efforts in the International Control Commission to implement the first Geneva Accords that ended the First Indochina War. [66] These negotiations, along with Indian involvement in the Taiwan Strait Crisis and in Lebanon, were seen positively in India, but less favourably in other countries. In fact, it often led to greater suspicions about Indian intentions in Washington, London, Moscow, Beijing, and other capitals. [67]

Perhaps the high point of independent India’s early leadership role in Asia was the 1955 Asian-African Conference in Bandung in Indonesia. Despite concerns from several participating countries, including the hosts, India insisted on China’s participation. Beijing was at the time still viewed with great suspicion in Asia, including in Southeast Asia. (In an apparent assassination attempt on Chinese Premier Zhou Enlai, an Air India plane